Mpho Parks Franklyn Tau

(tow)

Minister of Trade, Industry and Competition
Republic of South Africa

Addressed as: **Mr. Minister** | Office held since: **July 2024**

Parks Tau, who spent most of his career navigating local politics and tackling big urban challenges, is facing increasing pressure as trade minister as part of South Africa's tariff confrontation with the United States.

- **Hit By U.S. Trade War**
  Tau's tenure as trade minister has been dominated by crisis management. Trump's 30 percent tariffs—the highest imposed on any Sub-Saharan African country—threatened South Africa's exports, while AGOA's months-long lapse after September 2025 disrupted a quarter-century of duty-free access. Tau has accused the Trump administration of "negotiating in bad faith."

- **Hurt by Criticism**
  While Tau retains the trust of President Ramaphosa, he took a hit for the U.S. tariff debacle as the minister directly responsible for trade. The opposition and some trade associations blamed Tau for failing to develop a clear plan for exporters, making vague statements, and missing deadlines.

Tau's passion remains fighting inequality through urban development. He serves on an African National Congress (ANC) task force to help municipalities address service delivery and maintain infrastructure.

WHY THEY MATTER

Tau controls South Africa's trade and industrial policy at a moment when market access is in flux and localization requirements are tightening.

- **Gatekeeping Investment**
  Tau is driving a R700 billion investment pipeline and hosting the 6th South Africa Investment Conference in late March 2026. His vision centers on using foreign investment to rebuild local manufacturing capacity—not simply to serve as an export platform.

- **Willing to Intervene**
  Tau is quick to protect domestic industry. In 2025, he moved to support ArcelorMittal South Africa to preserve the steel sector and jobs. Weeks later, he imposed import duties on Chinese and Thai steel after finding evidence of dumping.

Tau remains cautious about the dominance of multinational retailers and their impact on local businesses. He has said he wants to ensure "trade happens in a manner that addresses the interests of the country, as well as our ability to grow the economy and create jobs."

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MEETING WITH THEM

Tau has a calm, measured demeanor and generally prefers detailed, policy-specific terminology even in media interviews.

- **Intensely Composed**
  He often comes off as aloof, but he is intensely composed and engaged. Media reports have noted his stillness—how he refrains from fidgeting and reins in his enthusiasm, even as he discusses his favorite global city, Barcelona. During tense tariff negotiations, he has maintained this composure, warning against "knee-jerk" responses.

- **Even-Keeled Tone**
  When addressing potentially contentious issues, he maintains an even-keeled tone. He doesn't express frustration or alarm, but instead calmly states his view, such as the future of the coalition government in South Africa.

His wife has publicly described him as "a very gentle and mellow man...he smiles through it all." For example, when asked about retaliating against U.S. tariffs, Tau said it would be a "counterproductive race to the bottom" and then pivoted to discussing engagement strategies.

ON THEIR MIND

- **Economic Fallout from Iran War**
  South African officials in late March underscore the need for caution as higher energy prices linked to the U.S.-Israel war against Iran threaten to push up inflation and cause fuel shortages.

- **G-7 Snub**
  The United States in late March allegedly put pressure on France to disinvite South African President Ramaphosa to the G7 summit in the French town of Evian in June, according to the South African presidency.

- **Tensions over Chinese and Thai Steel**
  South Africa in mid-March imposed steep import duties on structural steel imports from China and Thailand after finding evidence of dumping. The country's steel industry has been battling weak local demand and an influx of imports, mainly from China.

- **Police Corruption**
  South Africa's most senior policeman, Fannie Masemola, in March received a summons to answer claims linked to a health-services contract, allegations that came out of a judicial commission of inquiry into police corruption.

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NETWORK

Tau is struggling to develop rapport with U.S. counterparts in Washington, while deepening ties to interlocutors in Beijing as a hedge.

Tau met U.S. Trade Representative Jamieson Greer in Washington in September 2025 for what his department called a "cordial and constructive meeting"—but no breakthrough followed. Tau has since pivoted sharply toward Beijing: in February 2026, he led a delegation to sign the China-Africa Economic Partnership Agreement (CAEPA) with Commerce Minister Wang Wentao, securing 100 percent duty-free access to the Chinese market.

Tau is close to President Ramaphosa, ascending to a major portfolio despite his relative lack of trade experience. His working relationship with his Democratic Alliance deputy, however, ended in acrimony.

His partnership with Deputy Minister Andrew Whitfield initially started off quite well, but a turbulent relationship soon developed. Whitfield claimed Tau sidelined him for six months and denied him "line of sight" into key processes. Ramaphosa eventually fired Whitfield in June 2025 over an unauthorized trip to Washington.

CONTROVERSIES

Tau has faced sharp criticism from the opposition over the failure to secure a U.S. trade deal and lingering questions from his tenure as Johannesburg mayor.

- **Tariff Negotiations Fallout**
  The opposition Democratic Alliance has blamed Tau directly for "failing to secure a trade deal" with the United States, citing "negligence, failed diplomacy and ineptitude." The opposition noted that South African negotiators missed their first deadline and that Tau had no contingency plan when 30 percent tariffs took effect in August 2025.

- **Fraud Allegations as Mayor**
  There were 88 investigations into instances of fraud, theft, and corruption in 2012 alone when Tau served as Johannesburg mayor. South Africa's auditor general found tens of millions of dollars tied up in fraud cases. His wife's involvement in a company that received City of Johannesburg contracts also drew controversy.

Tau’s loyalty to the ruling ANC has resulted in some reputational and career hits. In April 2024, he was booed during a debate for celebrating 30 years of ANC successes. His election defeat as mayor in 2016 in part stemmed from growing dissatisfaction with ANC rule.

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CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

- **Minister of Trade, Industry and Competition**, Republic of South Africa (2024 to present)
- **Deputy Minister of Cooperative Governance and Traditional Affairs**, Republic of South Africa (2021 to 2024)
- **President**, United Cities and Local Governments (2016 to 2019)
- **Mayor**, City of Johannesburg (2011 to 2017)
- **Member**, Johannesburg City Council (1995 to 2011)
- **Youth activist,** anti-apartheid movement (1980s)

BIO

Parks Tau's political consciousness was shaped by the anti-apartheid struggle. **Born on June 6, 1970, in Soweto, he became involved in youth activism as a teenager, participating in organizations like the Congress of South African Students.**

- **Public Policy Background**
  Tau holds a Bachelor of Commerce degree in accounting from the University of South Africa (UNISA) and a master's degree in public policy and management from the University of London.

- **Family Woes**
  Tau is married to Pilisiwe Twala-Tau, who has also been involved in public service. She has been open about their marital woes, sharing that they were separated for a full year in 2003. One of their sons has discussed his struggles with suicide and drugs.

Tau speaks English and Setswana, and he attends services at a Methodist Church. While unconfirmed, he may have a slight preference for the Orlando Pirates Football Club over its main rival, the Kaizer Chiefs, based on a social media post.

NOTES